tenth of the normal level. Coupled with high winds—more than 50 kilometers per hour in Haifa, blowing from the arid east—Israel was a tinderbox. “The conditions are encouraging the development of such fires,” said Noah Wolfson, an Israeli meteorologist. “It could start with anything, a glass on the ground, like a magnifying glass, or people who forgot a small fire or barbecue.”

The conditions were similar in 2010, the year of Israel’s worst-ever wildfires, which started on Mount Carmel (adjacent to Haifa) and quickly spread across more than 12,000 acres. A total of forty-four people were killed, most of them officers in the prison service called in to help evacuate a jail; their bus got stuck on a highway and was consumed by the flames. It was a debacle for the Israeli government, which discovered it was ill-equipped to handle a major natural disaster. The flames were only extinguished with the help of airplanes sent from as far away as the United States.

Netanyahu promised to overhaul the emergency services, especially after a damning comptroller’s report issued a few years later. Yet Israel needed help again in 2016, with aircraft dispatched from around the Mediterranean; the Palestinian Authority sent several crews to help, too. But the response was markedly better than during the previous wildfires. While hundreds of people were hurt, there were no fatalities. The crew of a US supertanker spent their Thanksgiving Day flying to Israel. By the time they arrived, the authorities couldn’t find many fires for them to douse, and they spent hours doing idle loops over the Mediterranean. One other thing was different, though: the public reaction.

In the winter of 2015, Palestinian news agencies had reported that widespread flooding in Gaza was caused by Israel’s decision to open the gates of a nearby dam. It was a transparently false story, as anyone familiar with the region would immediately realize: there are no big rivers near the Gaza border, let alone a dam. But the claim rocketed around the world. Al Jazeera picked it up. So did AFP, one of the largest wire services. Israelis rightly mocked it as an example of shoddy journalism. But then they did the same thing—only with fire, instead of water.

Throughout the week, politicians, journalists, and ordinary citizens described the fires as a wave of terrorism. Naftali Bennett was among the first to suggest they were something sinister. “Only those to whom the land does not belong are capable of burning it,” he tweeted. He didn’t use the